

than for commercial purposes. It was released in various flavours, first in 1977, and is still in vogue. FreeBSD is a flavour that is free for use, and is maintained by a large group of individuals driven by sheer passion.

Many upgrades and newer versions followed as the server market continued to rely on the UNIX platform. In 1984, the Free Software foundation started the GNU (GNU is a recursive acronym for “GNU’s Not UNIX”) project, which aimed—out of enthusiasm—to develop a complete, free UNIX-like OS. Linux was to later use a lot of resources from GNU.

While all this was happening in the UNIX world, Microsoft introduced MS-DOS in 1981 and Windows 1.0 in 1983. However, network support came only in 1984, when a lot of systems were already running UNIX or its derivatives. Microsoft was thus a late entrant into the OS world, but owing to PC penetration into various markets—especially homes—Windows started getting popular.

In 1991, Sun Microsystems released their Solaris 2 OS. And in the same year, Linus Benedict Torvalds introduced Linux.

Torvalds had used UNIX at the University of Helsinki, and wanted to use UNIX at home too. He had a pretty powerful machine (for those days, we mean)—a 386DX 33 MHz CPU, 4 MB of RAM, but no co-processor (generally there is a math co-processor made specially to handle mathematical operations), and a 40 MB hard drive. He tried to get UNIX for his computer but could not afford it. Hence, he started out with Minix, a UNIX clone that could run on Intel processors, and which was used to teach UNIX at the University of Helsinki. Minix’s source code was not entirely available, so Torvalds wanted something better, and soon started to write his own OS.

After a few revisions, it was moderately functional, and soon attracted the attention of several “hackers,” who were interested